‘conservative faction’ in the SED to demonstrate how dangerously attractive Brandt was to East Germans.

Egon Krenz was never sure about the extent of Honecker’s involvement but was certain that Moscow had a hand in events. ‘You had to be very naive to assume that the applause for the West German guest would have been spontaneous and the crowd gathered there voluntarily.’6 According to Krenz, our ‘friends from Karlshorst’ – the seat of the Soviet secret service in the GDR – orchestrated the incident to warn Ulbricht of the dangers of acting on his own authority and getting too close to Brandt.7

Typically, ADN and TASS published a twisted version of events by reporting that hundreds of residents chanted ‘their full support for the policy of the GDR aimed at peace and security in Europe’.8 GDR Defence Minister Heinz Hoffman later admitted that the Erfurt kerfuffle ‘certainly strengthened Honecker’s conviction to force a policy of radical separation’.9

In the final analysis, not much was achieved in Erfurt, although Brandt named two positive developments. Firstly, a second discussion with Stoph would be held in Kassel on 21 May, and, moreover, the ‘argumentation of each side became more comprehensible to the other’.10 In the event, the Kassel meeting went smoothly but unproductively, bringing the sides no closer together.

Meanwhile, as Honecker resumed undermining Ulbricht’s rapprochement with the West, he received a sympathetic ear from Brezhnev, who was becoming weary of West German intentions toward the GDR.11 As references to his patron became more vinegary in flavour, Honecker continued to recycle a familiar litany of hate toward the FRG by claiming in Europe there were two worlds, ‘two diametrically opposed social systems … the peaceful strategy of socialism and the aggressive, expansionist strategy of imperialism’. He continued:

Playing the role of the spearhead of American global strategy in Europe, West German imperialism is particularly striving to